



University center Abdelhafid Boussouf - Mila
2019-2020 Semestre 1
E-Learning unit

English - level 1

– Lesson 4 –

Pronouns

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Etudiants concernés

Institut	Département	Année	Spécialité
-Lettres et Langues étrangères	- Français	-Français	Licence 1
-Sciences et Techniques	-MI- ST	-MI- ST	Licence 1
-Sciences Economique	-SE	-Toutes les spécialités	Licence 1

Objectives of lesson 1

- I. To make you aware of the existence of several types of pronouns.
- II. ***To empower you to distinguish the different types of pronouns English uses.**
- III. To prepare you to construct sentences in the future where pronouns are important elements.

Definition: Pronouns are words that substitute a noun or another pronoun. Examples of pronouns are *he, she, who, themselves...*

Examples:

***Aymen** is a doctor – (**He** is a doctor)

***A laptop** is on the desk – (**It** is on the desk)

1. Subject Pronouns

A **subject pronoun**, also called **subjective or subject personal pronoun**, is used as a substitute for proper and common nouns. A subject pronoun is used when the pronoun is the subject of the sentence.

A subject pronoun indicates:

- *number*: singular or plural
- *gender*: male or female
- *person*: first, second or third person

Example:

_____ did the job.

I, you, he, she, it, we, and they all fit into the blank and are, therefore, subject pronouns.

2. Object Pronouns

An **object pronoun**, also called **objective pronoun**, functions as the object of a verb or preposition, as distinguished from a subject or subjective pronoun, which is the subject of a verb.

Examples:

- She only told **them** the truth. (**them** is the object of the verb *told*)

Object pronouns are used instead of object nouns, usually because we already know what the object is.

- I like this film. I saw **it** last week.

Object pronouns in English are: **me, you, him, her, it, us, and them.**

Examples:

- I like **you** but you don't like **me**.
- He always writes e-mails to **us**.

3. Possessive Pronouns

A **possessive pronoun** is a part of speech that attributes ownership to someone or something. Like any other pronoun, it substitutes a noun phrase and can prevent its repetition. For example, in the phrase, "These glasses are **mine**, not **yours**", the words "**mine**" and "**yours**" are possessive pronouns and stand for "my glasses" and "your glasses," respectively.

Possessive pronouns are "**mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs**". They show who or what something belongs to.

Examples:

This is *our* house. It's **ours**.

This is *my* bedroom. It's **mine**.

4. Reflexive Pronouns

Reflexive pronouns are used when the **object** is the same as the **subject**. For example, in the sentence "**he** hurt **himself**", **he** and **himself** refer to the same person (a male person).

Reflexive pronouns are also used for emphasis. In this case, they are referred to as **intensive pronouns**. For example, in the sentence "I spoke to **the president himself**", the speaker emphasizes that she/he spoke to **the president** personally not somebody else.

The reflexive pronouns used in English are: *myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves*.

Example: "I always do my homework **myself**. Nobody helps me."

1. Reflexive pronouns are used when the subject and the object refer to the same thing: **He** blames **himself** for what had happened.
2. Reflexive pronouns may be used as the object of a preposition:
He made a cup of coffee **for himself**

5. Demonstrative Pronouns

A demonstrative pronoun points out specific persons, places, or things.

Demonstrative pronoun		
singular	This	These
plural	That	Those

This is your homeroom.

These are your classmates.

That will be your seat.

6. Indefinite Pronouns

Unlike demonstrative pronouns, which point out specific items, indefinite pronouns are used for non-specific things. This is the largest group of pronouns.

All, some, any, several, anyone, nobody, each, both, few, either, none, one, and no one are the most common indefinite pronouns English uses..

Examples:

- Somebody must have seen the driver leave.
(Somebody is not a specific person.)
- We are all in the gutter, but some of us are looking at the stars.
- I have nothing to declare except my genius.

7. Relative Pronouns

A relative pronoun is a pronoun that introduces a relative clause. It is called a "relative" pronoun because it "relates" to the word that its relative clause modifies. Here is an example:

- The person **who** phoned me last night is my teacher.

In the above example, "**who**":

- relates to "The person", which "who phoned me last night" modifies.
- introduces the relative clause "who phoned me last night".

There are five basic relative pronouns: **who**, **whom**, **whose**, **which**, **that**.

Who (subject) and **whom** (object) are generally only for people. **Whose** is for possession. **Which** is for things. **That** can be used for things and people only in *defining* relative clauses (clauses that are essential to the sentence and do not simply add extra information).

8. Interrogative pronouns

We use the interrogative pronouns to ask questions. The interrogative pronoun represents the thing that we do not know (what we are asking the question about).

There are five main interrogative pronouns: who, whom, what, which and whose

	Subject	Object
Person	Who	Whom
Thing	What	
Person/thing	Which	
Person	Whose	

Who told you? ⇨ John told me (Subject)

Whom did you tell? ⇨ told Mary (Object)

Whose car hasn't arrived? $\Rightarrow$ **John's (car)** hasn't arrived (object)

Which came first? $\Rightarrow$ **The Porsche** came first (subject)

What do you want? $\Rightarrow$ I want **coffee** (object)

**** Whom** is tricky, and is falling into disuse because many people do not know how to use it correctly. **Who** is a subject pronoun, while **whom** is an **object pronoun**; it should only be used as the object of a verb – e.g. 'To **whom** shall I address the parcel?', 'By **whom** was the letter sent?', 'Whom shall I ask?'

References

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- 4) Murdphy. R. (2012). English Grammar in Use. Cambridge. Cambridge University Press.
- 5) Chalker. S. (1992). A Student's English Grammar. Longman: England.